

Germany: AfD is likely to rule after landslide victory

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The AfD likely to rule after landslide state election victory

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Short-term trajectory:

Long-term trajectory:

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There is a 55% probability the far-right Alternative for Germany (AfD) will form a government in the state of Saxony-Anhalt after elections on 6 September failed to deliver a clear majority.

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Chancellor Friedrich Merz's government is not at risk in the near term, but Merz himself will come under intense scrutiny in his own party as more negative CDU results from state elections this month are looming, and a viable challenger could emerge from the more consequential state elections in North Rhine-Westphalia in April 2027.

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Germany's support for Ukraine is not at risk after the AfD's success, but German electoral trends could be a signpost that increased voter turnout no longer strengthens the political center, a development that could impact France's presidential election next year.

Elections in Saxony-Anhalt on 6 September delivered no clear majority but left the AfD in a position where it may still form a government. The AfD more than doubled its 2021 result, gaining 43.8% of the vote. It will remain three seats short of an absolute majority in the state parliament, and will now seek to recruit defectors from other parties to switch their allegiance and enable an AfD majority. There is a 55% probability the party will succeed over the next weeks or months. The chances of an AfD minority government or new elections after government formation fails are 20% each. The formation of an all-party coalition or minority government against the AfD is unlikely (5%).

The Social Democrats (SPD) scored 9.3%, the Greens won 8.9%, with the post-communist Left Party gaining 8.6% of the vote. The left-leaning Alliance Sarah Wagenknecht (BSW) narrowly cleared the 5% threshold.

Merz will face increased criticism within his own conservative party, but an open revolt remains unlikely until at least the spring of 2027. The CDU, so far the strongest political force in the state, scored 17.2%, less than half of its 2021 result, a disastrous outcome that sent shockwaves through Merz's party. Rumors about an imminent threat to his position as party leader and chancellor are legion, but likely misplaced. No viable challenger will emerge before the crucial state elections in North Rhine-Westphalia

(NRW) on 25 April 2027, Germany's biggest and politically weightiest state. Hendrik Wüst, NRW's moderately conservative prime minister, is Merz's most likely successor but is unlikely to make a risky move against the chancellor before receiving a fresh mandate from voters back home.

National government stability is not at risk, but disillusionment will grow. Policy outcomes become even harder to achieve in a polarized political environment. There is only a 20% chance of government collapse within the next six months. Weakness will keep the coalition afloat as neither CDU/CSU nor SPD are keen to seek a premature end to the current constellation for fear of the almost certain punishment by voters in case of early elections. But policy output will remain small-scale and limited as the common ground between the coalition partners is diminished with each disappointing state election result. This logic leads to a self-reinforcing political dynamic that feeds the AfD's rise: the weaker the election results, the less common ground in the coalition, the fewer the policy results. The fewer results, the bigger the frustration in the electorate, the bigger the AfD's share of the vote. Neither Merz, for whom there is now even less space to adopt the more conservative posture desired by his party, nor the SPD leadership have so far found a way to break out of this vicious circle.

Merz will likely harden his stance on the EU's budget negotiations. Germany's support for Ukraine will not be affected, nor will Germany's hardening position on China or its increased efforts to rebuild and modernize its armed forces. However, there will now be even less space for Merz, a proponent of a more frugal EU, to compromise in negotiations over the bloc's next multi-annual financial framework (MMF).

The AfD's result will encourage populists elsewhere in Europe. Saxony-Anhalt's result has refuted the traditional assumption that a significantly increased voter turnout by default benefits centrist parties. A record turnout of 78% (up from 60.3% in 2021), driven primarily by the activation of former abstainers, disproportionately benefited the AfD. While there are limits to comparing proportional state parliament elections in Germany to the two-round presidential election in France, both countries are undergoing a dramatic restructuring of their party systems, leaving disoriented voters willing to choose untested and more radical options. Germany's "firewall" against the AfD, i.e., the systematic denial of any participation in an AfD government by all other parties, will now be judged a failure, potentially opening the door to comparable political forces elsewhere.

The AfD proposes strongly anti-Euro and EU-skeptical policies, strict anti-immigration measures, the lifting of all sanctions on Russia, and ending support for Ukraine. It also suggests lower taxes, significantly increased pensions and welfare transfers, and Germany's adherence to fiscal discipline and its constitutional debt brake. The AfD wishes to bring about the "healing" of what it considers Germany's unhealthy focus on historic guilt and its lack of patriotic sentiment. It aims to end the "ideologically driven climate policies of the last decades" and to reintroduce nuclear power generation.

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